

## Usability

All three notebooks were huge and heavy; however clever design hides the bulkiness of the Dell D800. The ACi Ultima is a monster, weighing 4 kg, thanks mainly to the 17-inch screen.

Ergonomics is a non-issue with the D800; the keyboard is well laid-out with good spacing between the keys. The touchpad buttons are large and hard to miss, however the tactile feel isn't the best. Dell also provides a pointing stick for lazy fingers.

ACi's Emerald M10 and Ultima can't match the Dell D800 on ergonomics; nevertheless they offer the best for the price one pays for them.

Heating issues are omnipresent in all notebooks, and it is compounded in notebooks that use desktop processors due to the higher thermal envelope that they are designed with. All the three notebooks in this category were no exceptions -their under-surface heats up after a while. For the ACi's, the palm rest and the keyboard heated up—very uncomfortable.



Dell  
Latitude  
D800

ACi Emerald M10

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## Reliance GTRAN Card

The sole purpose of Reliance Infocom's GTRAN card is to provide Internet connectivity on the go. All you need to do is plug it into the PCMCIA slot. This card works on CDMA 1x technology and theoretically provides 153 Kbps of peak data throughput. Your mobile phone gets tied up when you use it for a dial-up connection. GTRAN solves this problem by providing Internet connectivity. Reliance offers the GTRAN card for Rs 14,700 with 3 tariff plans. You pay 40 paise/minute flat in the first plan. The second and third plan offers 100 MB and 500 MB of data exchange for a flat fee of Rs 500 and Rs 1000, respectively. You shell out an extra Rs 10 for each additional MB of data exchange.

The D800 has great ventilation and doesn't face these problems.

## Performance

ACi's Emerald M10 and Dell D800 were on par in almost all the tests except for the *Call of Duty* game, where the M10 beat the D800 hollow. The better performance of ACi's M10 is quite evident, since the M10 uses a Hyper-Threaded processor with a difference of almost 1 Ghz in clock speeds. The Pentium M processor in the D800 matches the M10's desktop variant.

System intensive tests, such as ZDBench, video encoding, etc., saw the ACi Emerald M10 slip ahead of the Dell D800 by a small margin, and similar results were seen across all the tests that we put these two laptops through. The ACi's Ultima proved to be a mediocre performer when compared to other two notebooks in this category.

The Dell D800 offers twice the battery life as compared to both models from ACi. This is one of the advantages that the power optimized Centrino platform offers without cutting out much on the performance aspect.

All three notebooks are supported by three years of warranty. While ACi offers a carry-in warranty, Dell offers on-site warranty coverage, additionally due to its global presence, one also gets an international warranty.

The claimed turn-around-time is 48 hours for ACi laptops, and 24 hours for Dell.

## Conclusion

Riding high on features, usability, equally impressive performance and excellent service and support, Dell's Latitude D800 takes the crown. However, its high price will be a stumbling block for many potential buyers.

If you don't give much importance to brand value, and want a powerful notebook, then ACi's Emerald M10 is the best solution on offer at a reasonable price.

## ULTRA-PORTABLES

Ultra-portables offer computing power in the smallest possible form-factor. The bonsai act leaves them crippled on the performance front, since most of them use low-power processors to squeeze out the most from the tiny batteries.